

Designing for Real People 2026

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Royal College of Art

Imperial College Mech Eng
Masters from the RCA
PhD Imperial College

30 years in the IT Industry



Designing for Real People 2026

What you will learn in this course:

The principles, practice, tools and approaches that will help you to design innovative solutions for real people and bring meaningful value to their lives...and demonstrate this by designing and delivering a real solution

Structure of Programme

Creating value, designing with values



Project Reviews

Milestone 1 - 22.5

May Milestone 2 - 29.5

Milestone 3 - 5 June

Milestone 4 - 12 June

Final Reviews - 16/17 June

DESIGNING FOR REAL PEOPLE 2026

This first lecture is in 4 Parts

- Introduction to the RCA and the Course
- Principles of Life Centred Design
- Design of Product Service Systems
- Finding Meaningful Opportunities for Design



The Royal College of Art

World leading university for art and design for the last eight years (QS Rankings 2015-22)



The RCA started life in 1837 as the Government School of Design, and became the Royal College of Art in 1896.



Painting students in the Mural Room, Royal College of Art c.1936 Courtesy of the Royal College of Art.

COMMUNICATION



John Pashe



Peter Blake



Storm Thorgerson

FASHION



Claire Waight Keller



Christopher Bailey



Bianca Saunders



Philip Treacy

AUTOMOTIVE



Peter Stevens



Gerry McGovern



Ian Callum

TRANSPORT



Paul Priestman



Margaret Calvert



Thomas Heatherwick

PRODUCT DESIGN



James Dyson



Barber Osgerby



Azumi



Konstantin Grcic

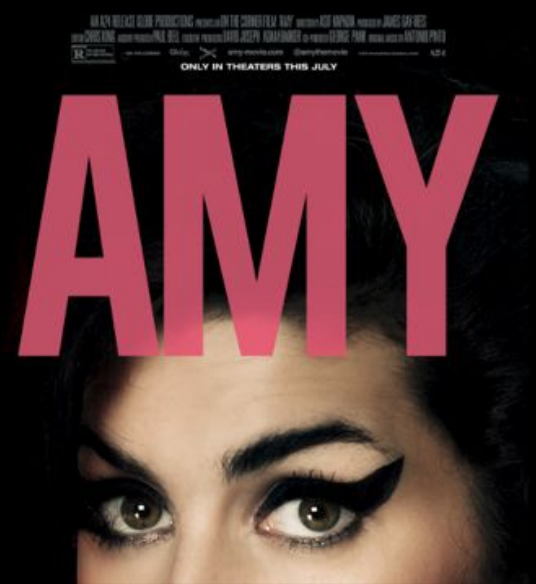
FILM & TV



Ridley Scott

Channel 4

Neville Brody



Asif Kapadia

RESEARCH INTENSIVE



World-leading, research-intensive institution (REF2014, REF2021).

RESEARCH INTENSIVE

Helen Hamlyn
Centre for
Design

Helix Centre

Intelligent
Mobility
Design Centre

Materials
Science
Research
Centre

Robotics
Lab

Computer
Science
Research
Centre

Design Age
Institute

Textiles
Circularity
Centre

1991

2013

2016

2018

2018

2020

2020

2021

GENERATION



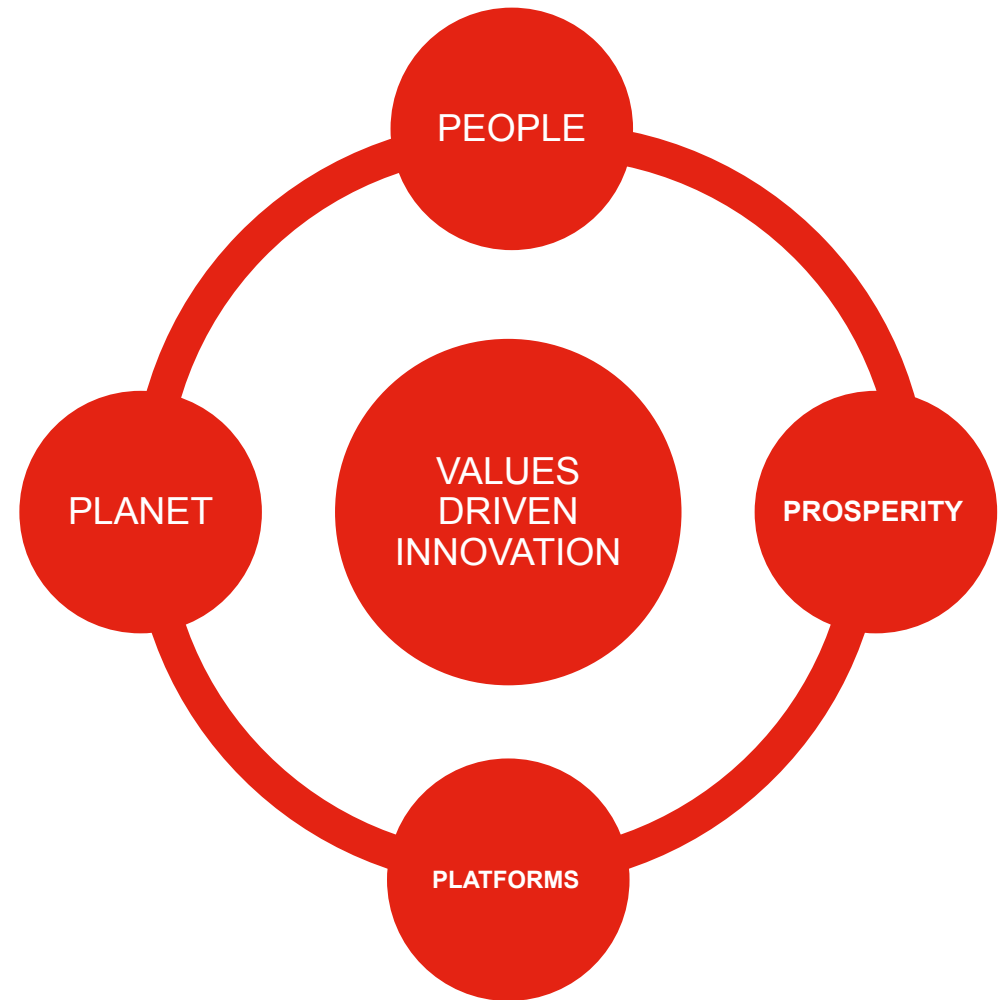
Royal College of Art

DESIGN 360°

4 pillars: people, planet, platforms and prosperity

Your innovation approach must take into account:

- Economic sustainability as well as environmental sustainability
- Exploit technology to create virtuous collisions with society not car crashes
- The impact of our innovations on society – designing with not for society

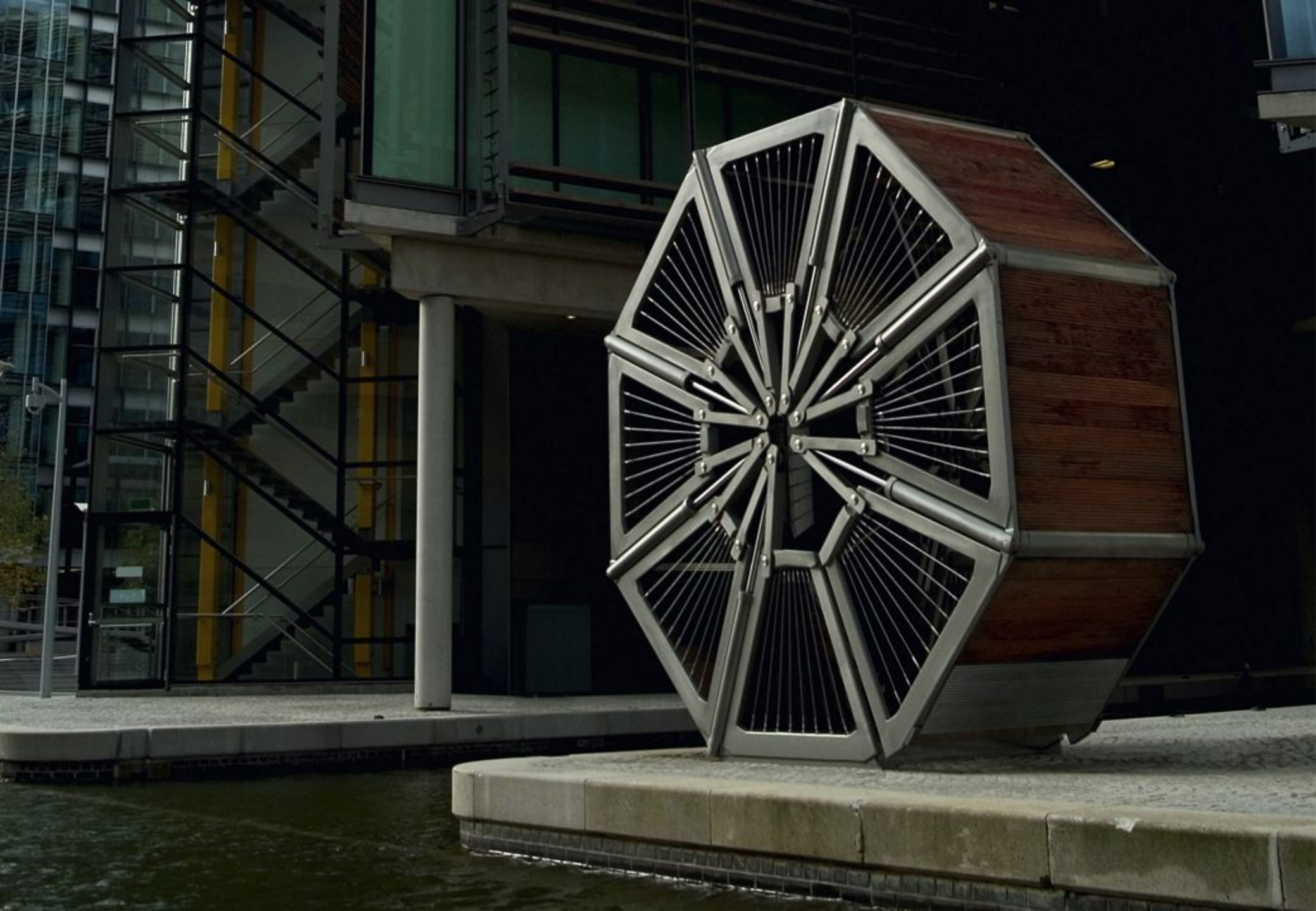


PART 2: AN INTRODUCTION TO THE DESIGN PROCESS

CLASS EXERCISE



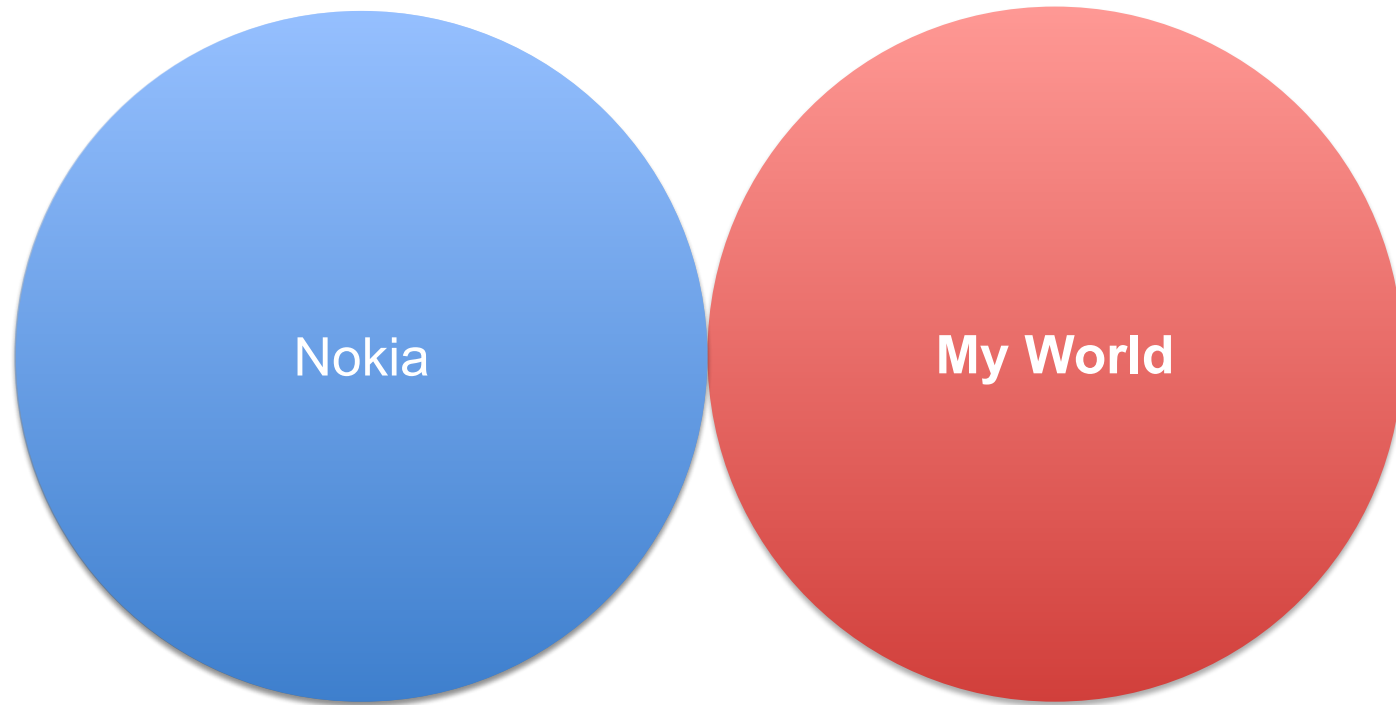




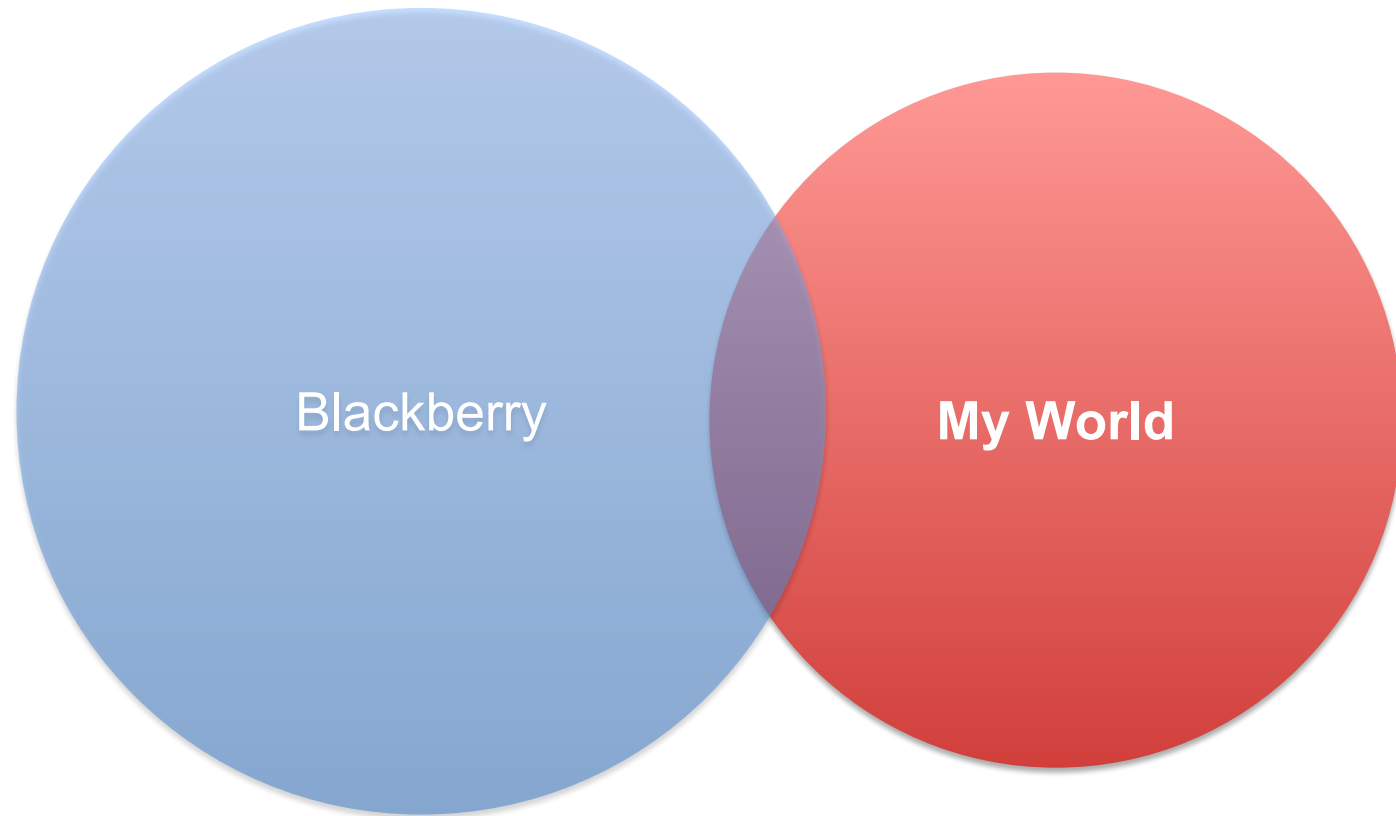


DESIGN THINKING AND CREATING VALUE FOR CUSTOMERS AND USERS

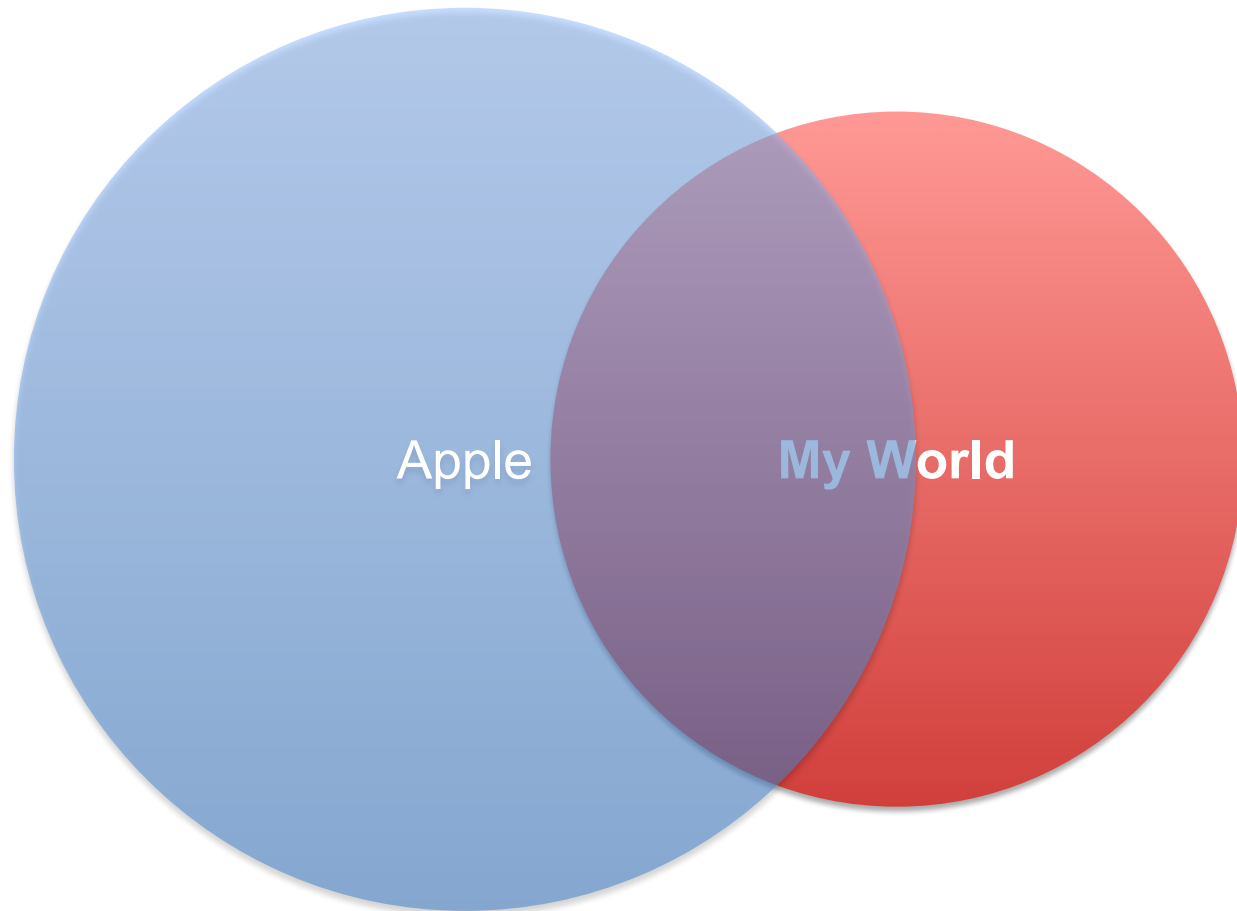
All the Value is on the Right Hand Side of the Page –
and this needs the right hand side of your brain



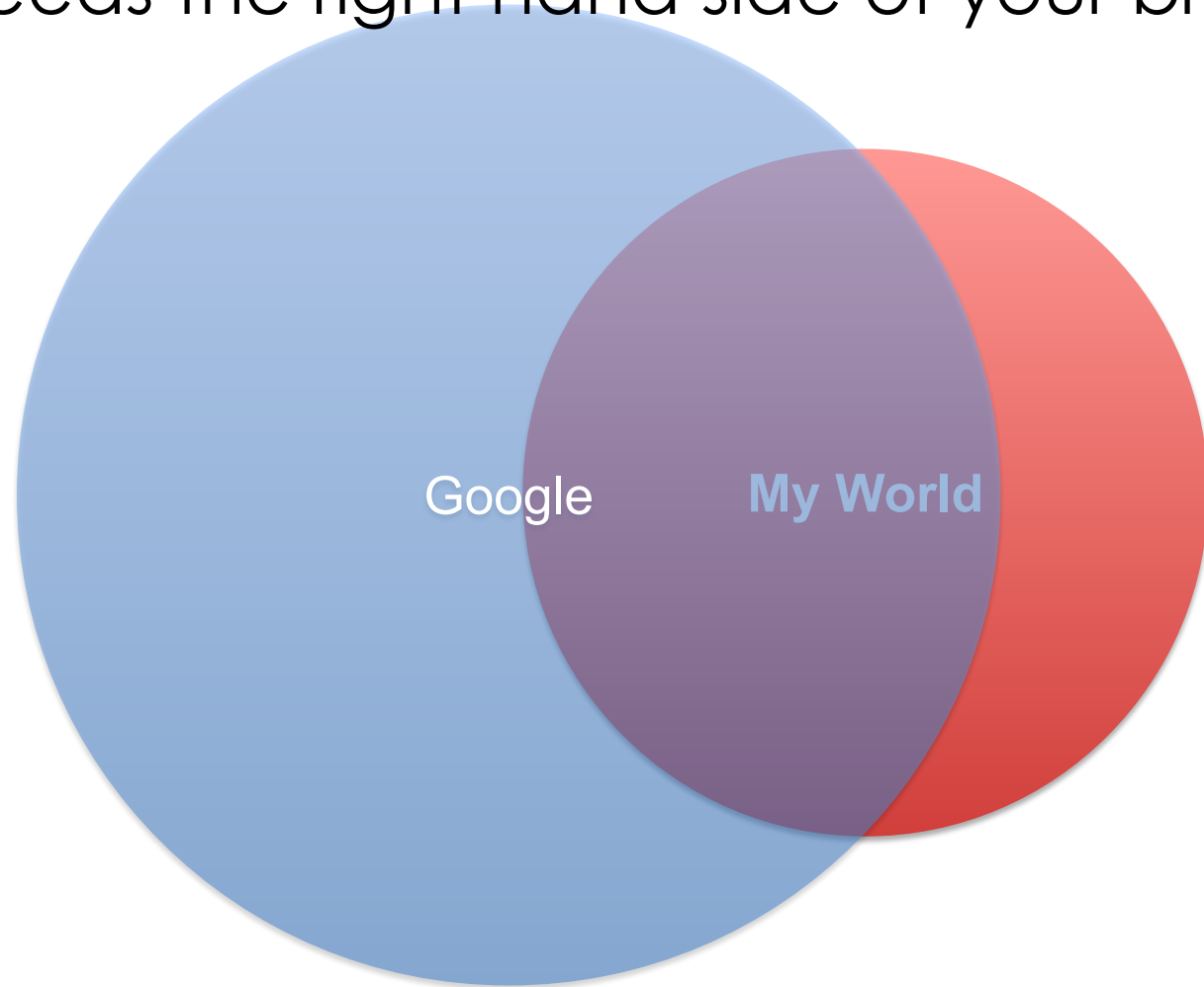
All the Value is on the Right Hand Side of the Page –
and this needs the right hand side of your brain



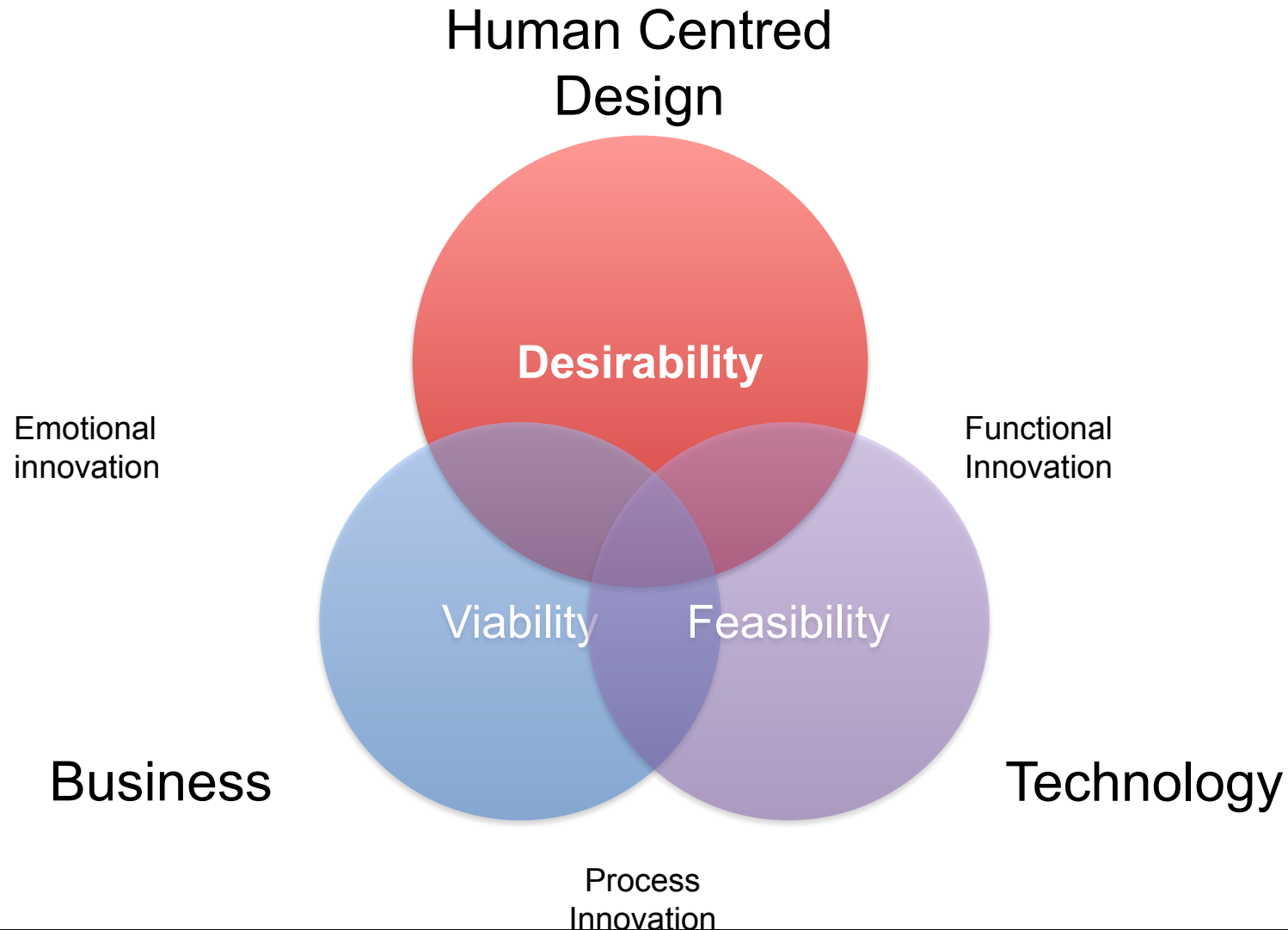
All the Value is on the Right Hand Side of the Page –
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All the Value is on the Right Hand Side of the Page –
and this needs the right hand side of your brain

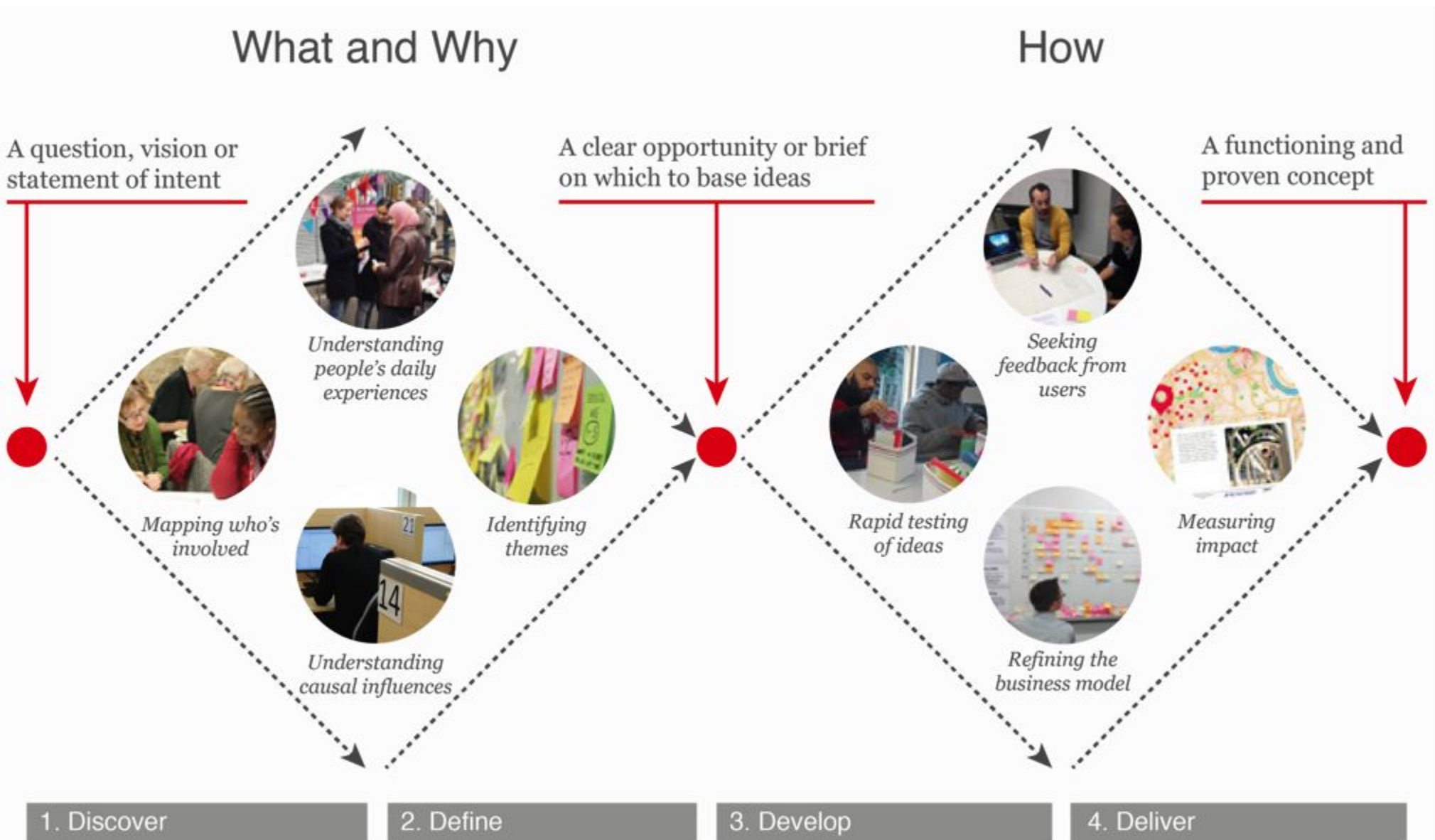


Design Thinking: an interdisciplinary approach to innovation that puts people at its heart

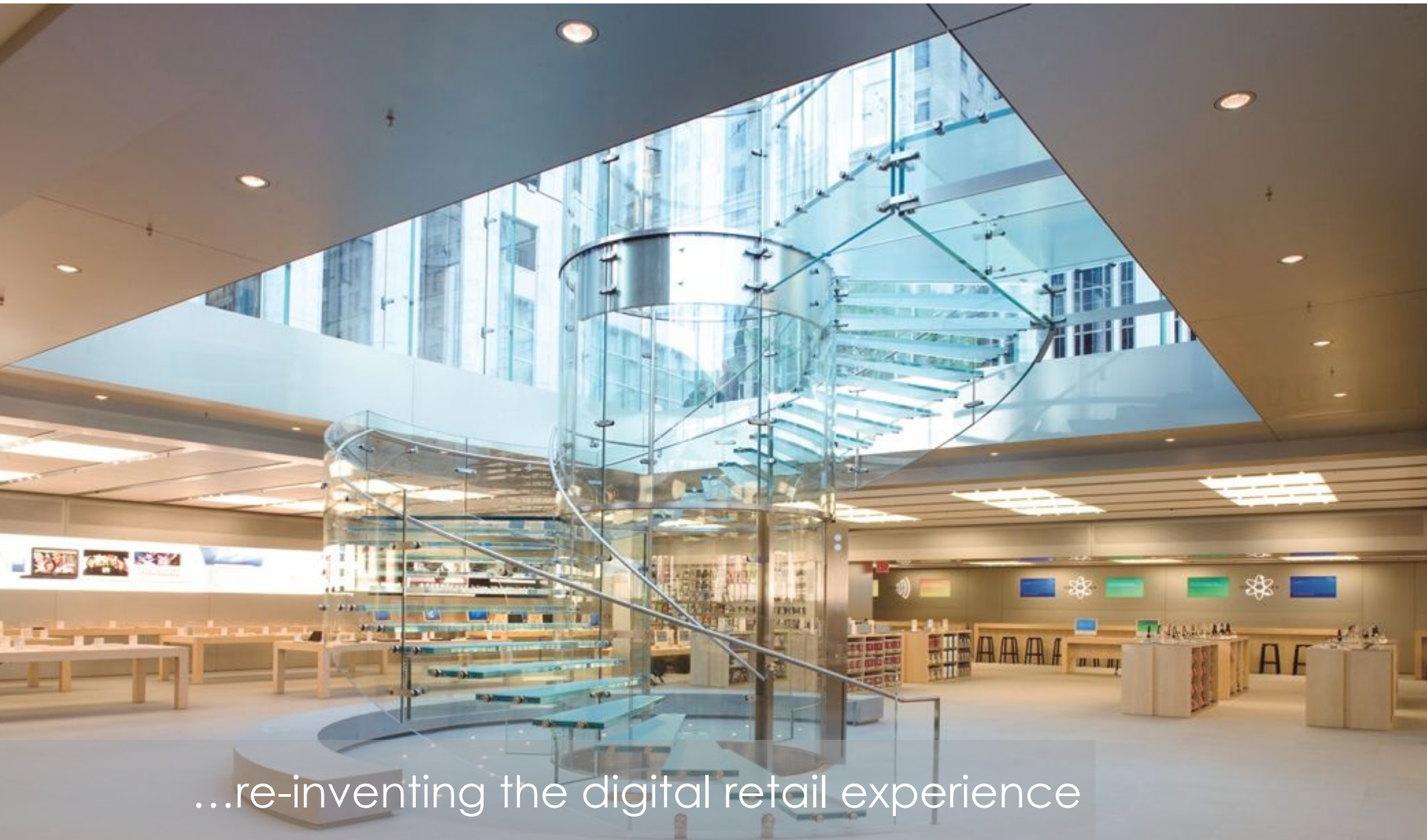


DESIGN LED INNOVATION STAGES

1. **Discover:** gather insights
2. **Define:** frame the right problem
3. **Develop:** ideation with the key stakeholders...
“how might we?” and prototype and test
4. **Deliver:** design and deploy from minimum viable pilot to minimum viable product



DESIGNING THE TOTAL CUSTOMER EXPERIENCE NOT JUST A PRODUCT OR COMPONENT



...re-inventing the digital retail experience

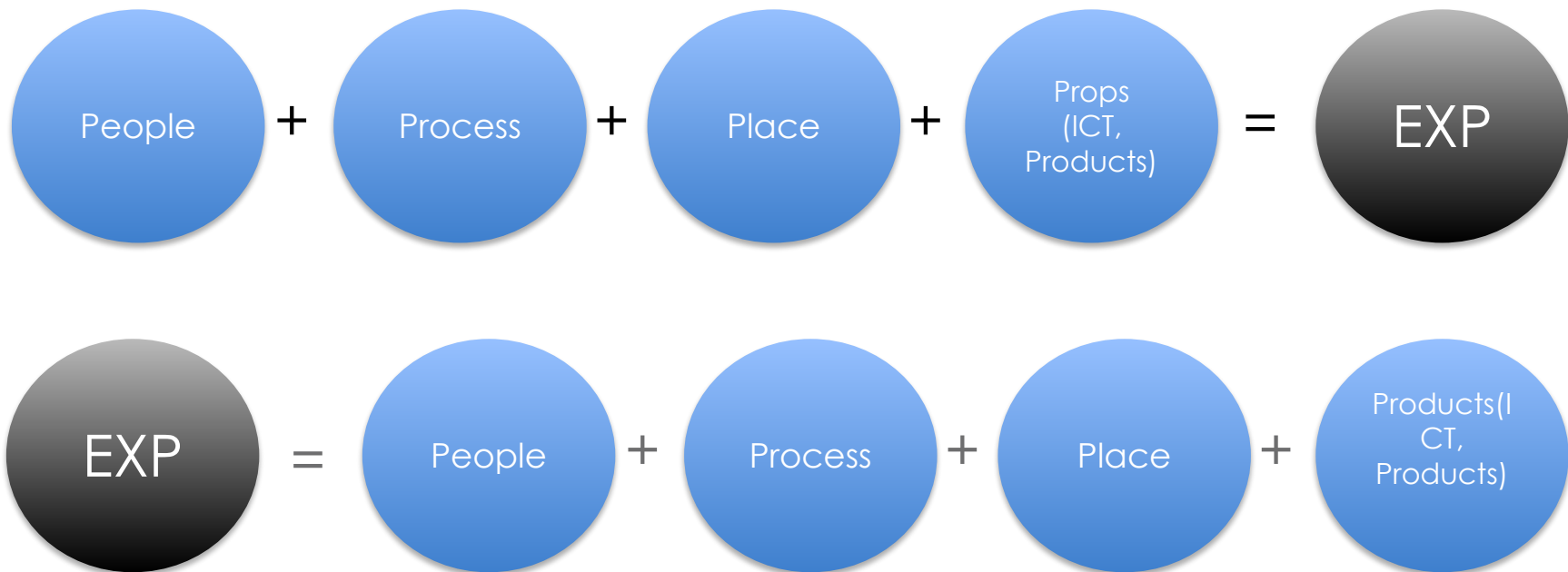
Customer Experience led Enterprises

“Uber, the world’s largest taxi company, owns no vehicles. Facebook, the world’s most popular media owner, creates no content. Alibaba, the most valuable retailer, has no inventory. And Airbnb, the world’s largest accommodation provider, owns no real estate. Something interesting is happening. “

Tom Goodwin
Senior vice president of strategy and innovation at Havas Media

Designing the total user experience not just a product or component

EXPERIENCE LED DESIGN



Nespresso - redefining the coffee experience





Deliver a total brand experience: **Nespresso Barcelona**



...delivering a total brand experience

NESPRESSO

[Login](#) [Register](#) [Shopping bag](#)  

COFFEE

MACHINES

THE CLUB

ECOLABORATION

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The Club

By combining our clever coffee capsule with our high tech machine, we have mastered the art of the perfect espresso. The Nespresso Club is dedicated to providing the ultimate coffee experience.

NESPRESSO.Club

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ecolaboration[™]
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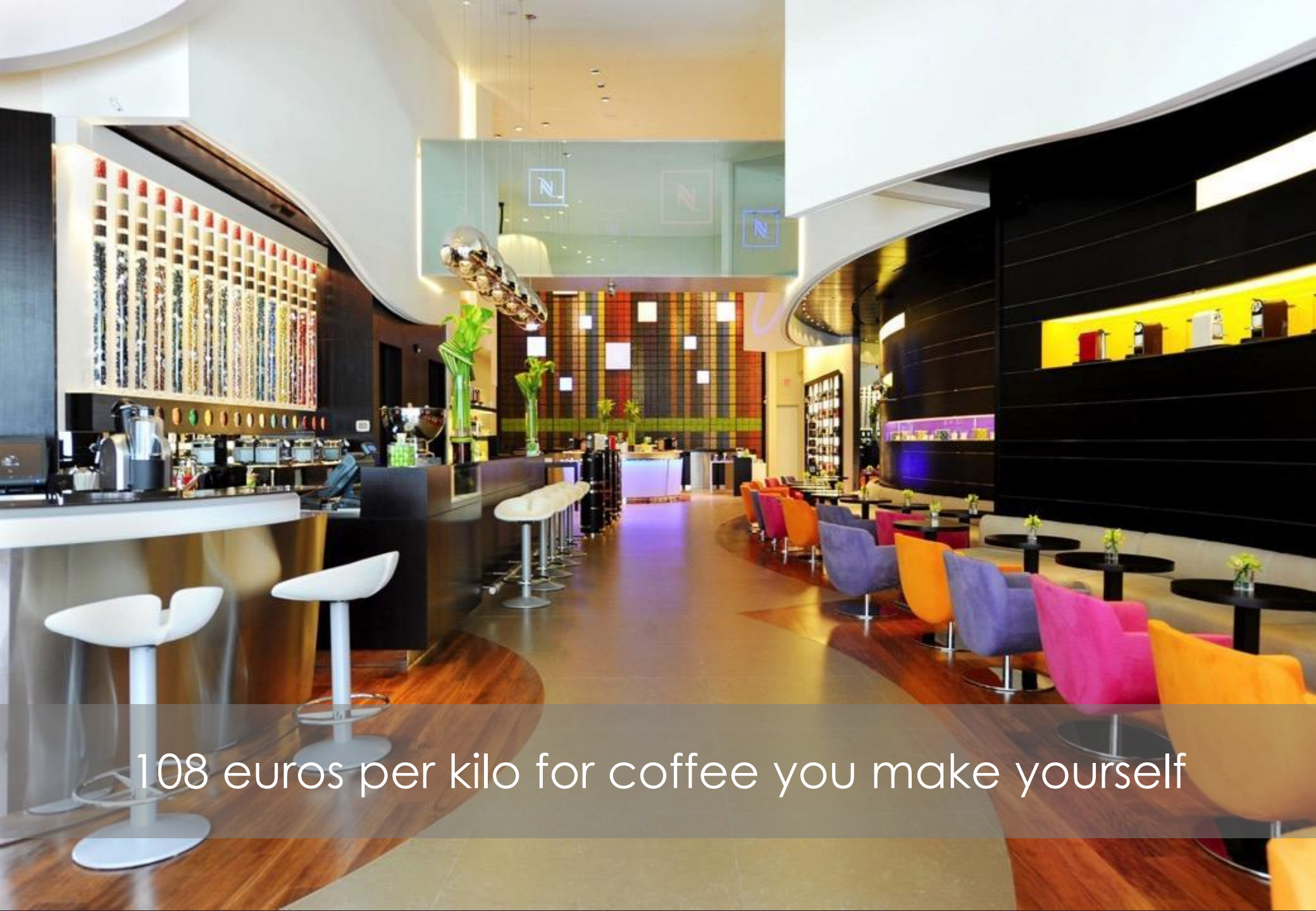
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Have the capacity to collect 75% of used capsules

[Learn more](#)YOU ARE HERE : [HOME](#)

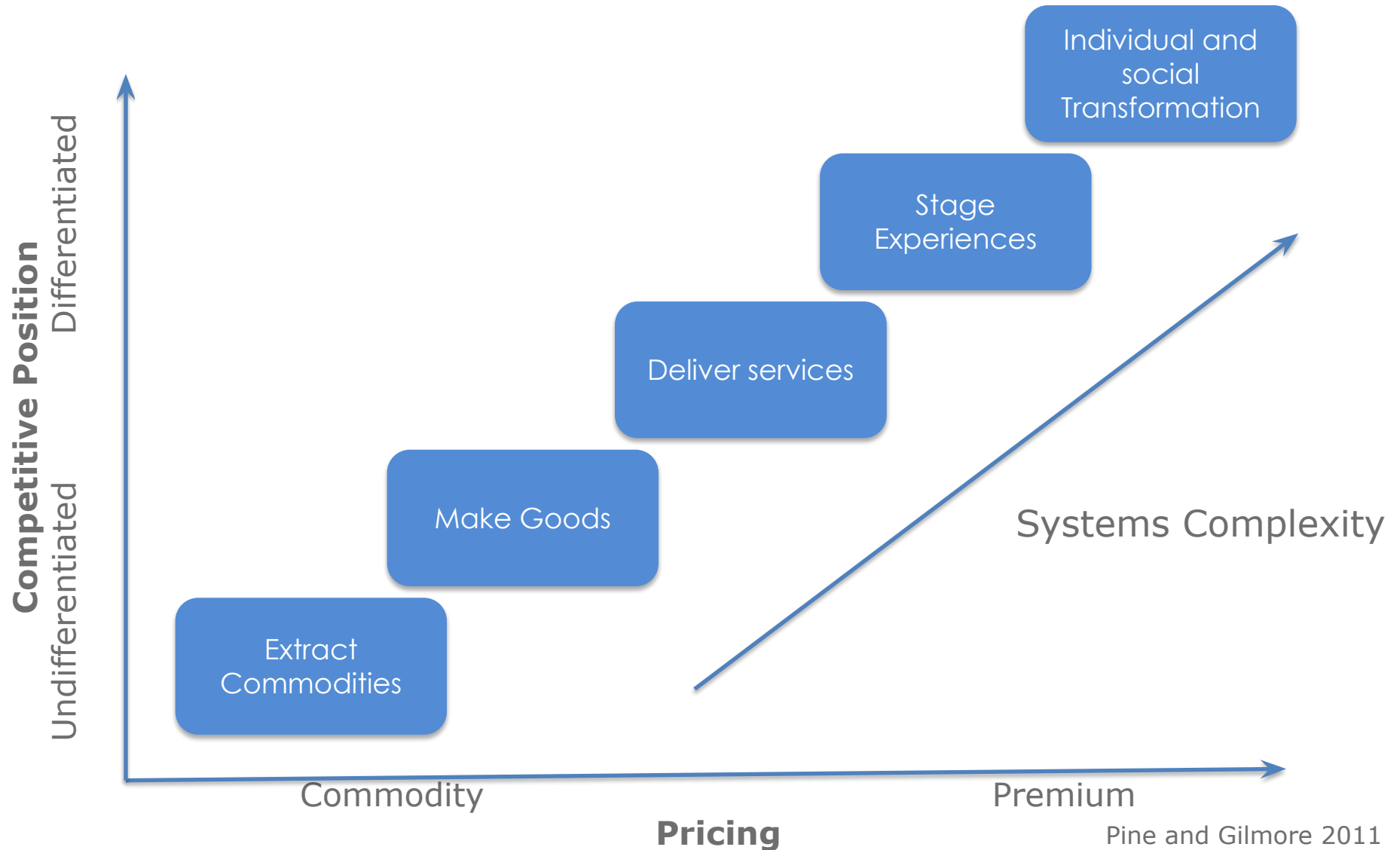
ECOLABORATION IN ACTION



108 euros per kilo for coffee you make yourself

PART 3: DESIGNING PRODUCT SERVICE SYSTEMS

PROGRESSION OF ECONOMIC VALUE AND SYSTEMS COMPLEXITY



Pine and Gilmore 2011



GE ultrasound scanner

Consider Systems and Stakeholders



<https://vimeo.com/97033464>

2. THE TERRA CARTA DESIGN LAB

'The "Terra Carta" offers the basis of a recovery plan that puts Nature, People and Planet at the heart of global value creation - one that will harness the precious, irreplaceable power of Nature combined with the transformative innovation and resources of the private sector.'

His Majesty, King Charles III



THE TERRA CARTA DESIGN LAB



ZELP Neutralises livestock methane exhalations at the source, providing an efficient and scalable solution for farmers, companies, and governments.



ZELP

A black and white cow is lying in a grassy field under a blue sky with scattered clouds. The cow is wearing a black, futuristic-looking device around its head and snout. The device has a large, bulbous, black, teardrop-shaped protrusion at the end of its snout, which is designed to capture methane as the cow breathes. The cow's head is turned slightly to the right.

ZELP neutralises livestock methane exhalations at the source, providing an efficient and scalable solution for farmers, companies, and governments.

THE TYRE COLLECTIVE



Spearheading the capture and monitoring of tyre wear, accelerating the shift towards zero-emission mobility.

EARTHSOT WINNER 2022

MAKING
WAVES!

Fourteen million tonnes of plastic enter our oceans each year. We founded **Notpla** when we discovered the solution lies in our oceans too. We are already replacing plastic that plagues our seas, and working with seaweed farms that give back to the environment and the local economy.



EARTHSOT WINNER 2022



TERRA CARTA IMPACT

5 Ventures from the Terra Carta Design Lab who together have raised investments of over £30m with valuations in excess of £100m



PART 4: IDENTIFYING OPPORTUNITIES



Mobile Everything

Social Media and
Collaborative Innovation

Wearable and
Embedded Technology

Nano-Technology and
Smart Materials

Big Data, Analytics

Cloud Computing

Smart Materials

Internet of Things

IF TECHNOLOGY'S THE ANSWER, WHAT IS THE QUESTION?



Population Growth – 9.7bn

Global Warming

Demographic

Species Extinction – 6th great event

Economic Disparity

Contaminated Planet

Food Production – 70% Growth

SYSTEMIC ISSUES – BIG CHALLENGES FOR 2050

5801

**Working Days to 2050
We cannot waste a second**

**SYSTEMIC ISSUES DEMAND A
SYSTEMIC SERVICE LED RESPONSE**

225 days x 25.77years



The Goals are the output of the largest consultation the UN has ever undertaken.

Over 8 million people consulted, 70 countries in the working parties and 193 nations signed

They are a compelling articulation by humanity of the world we want

Design driven innovation attributes

- Redefining systems not just its components
- Delivering Experiences not just products
- Introducing and controlling platforms
- Exploiting network effects of users as well eco-system

And Some Personal Tips

- Design verbs not nouns
- Use the right hand side of the brain on the right hand side of the page
- Know your user: their life, their needs and what they value
- Don't just satisfy the average... wow the extremes
- Combine big data with little data to have a massive impact